

GETTING THINGS DONE

THE ART OF STRESS-FREE PRODUCTIVITY

"It is possible to have an overwhelming number of things to do and still function productively with a clear head and a positive sense of relaxed control."

A guide to the methodology of David Allen

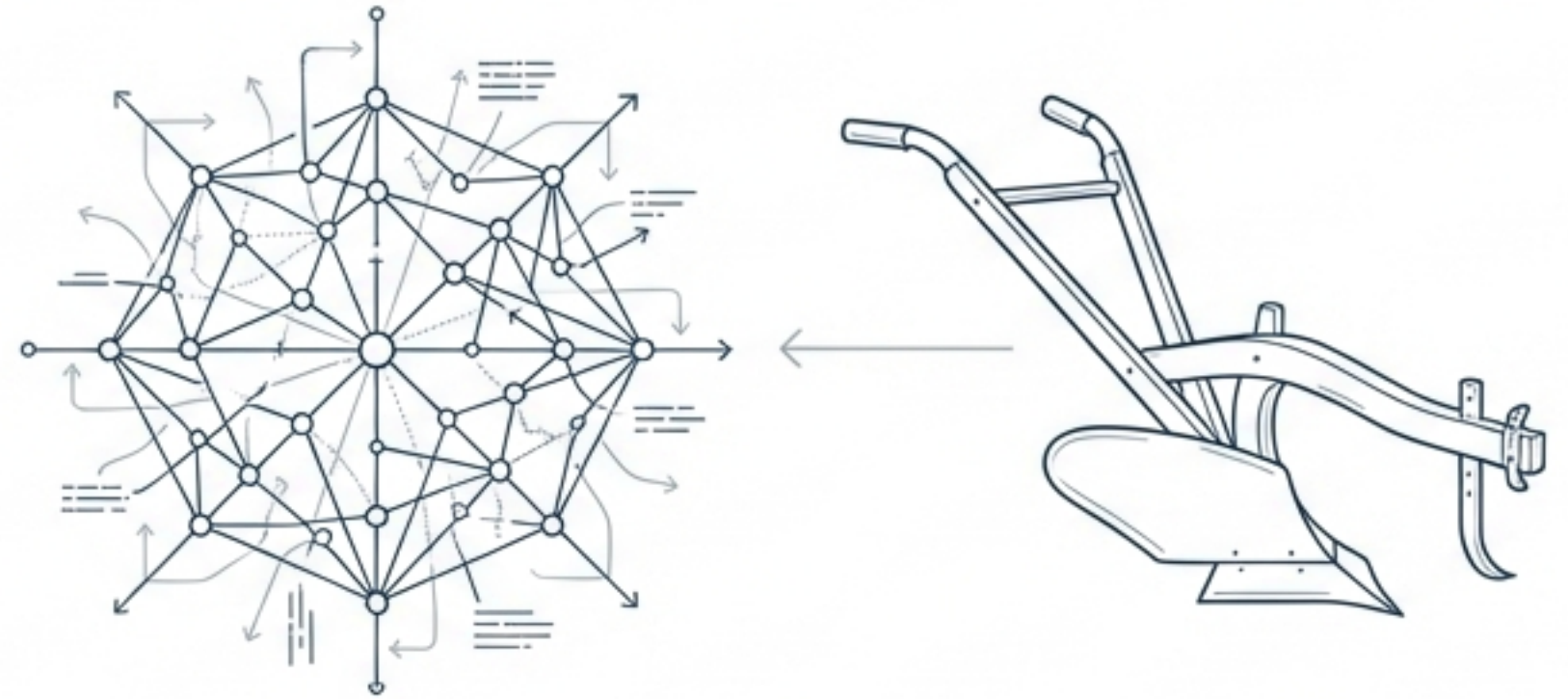


Knowledge work has no boundaries

The Shift: Work has transformed from industrial 'make-it and move-it' tasks to ambiguous 'knowledge work'.

The Challenge: Most projects have no clear edges. They are never truly 'finished' and can always be improved with infinite data.

The Result: We accept huge volumes of information but lack the equipment to manage the internal commitments they generate.



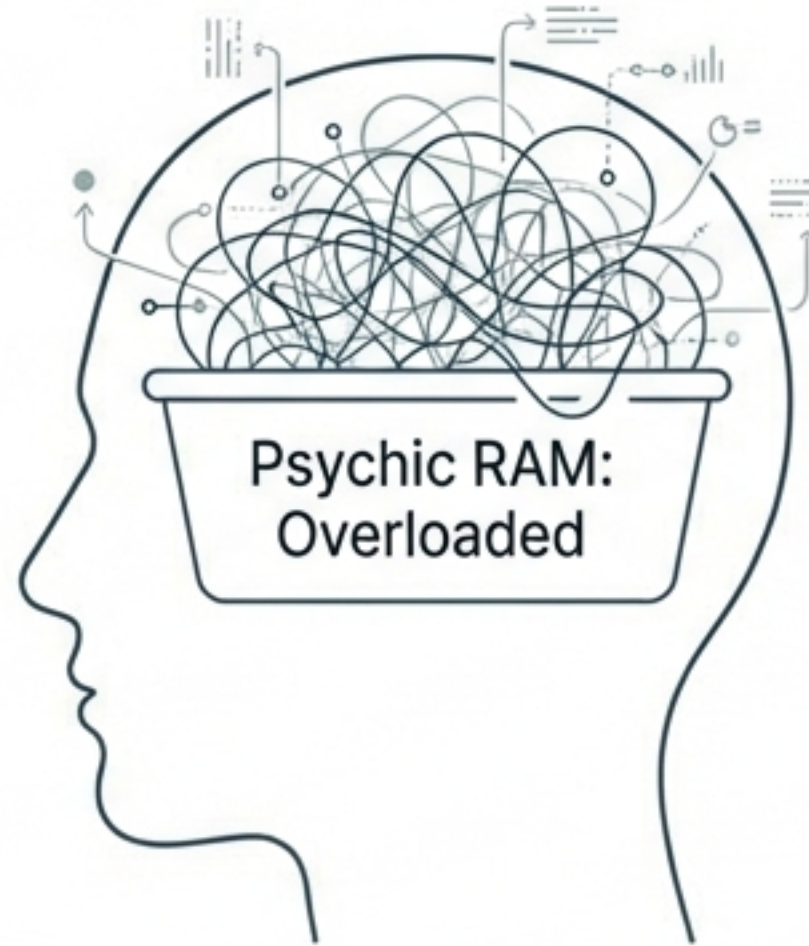
New Work:
Invisible, Infinite

Old Work:
Visible, Finite

In knowledge work... the task is not given; it has to be determined. — Peter F. Drucker

Why you feel overwhelmed

The Problem of Open Loops



1. The mind has limited capacity.
2. It has no sense of past or future—it thinks you must do everything NOW.
3. Two incomplete tasks in memory = Automatic Failure (you cannot do both at once).

Open Loop: Anything pulling at your attention that doesn't belong where it is, the way it is.

The Objective: Mind Like Water

The Goal:
Engagement without
distraction.



The Physics of Flow: Water responds appropriately to the mass of the input, then returns to calm. It does not overreact or underreact.

The Application: High performance requires the ability to clear the mind. If you stress over an email (overreaction) or ignore a deadline (underreaction), you are controlled by the input.

The Five Stages of Mastering Workflow



Most people try to do all five at once. They must be separated to be effective.

Phase 1: Collect

The Mission: Corral your “stuff”. Identify anything that you think should be different than it is.

The Success Factors

1. Get it all out of your head (Clear the mind).
2. Minimize buckets (Use as few as possible).
3. Empty regularly (Don't use “In” as storage).

Tools



Physical in-basket



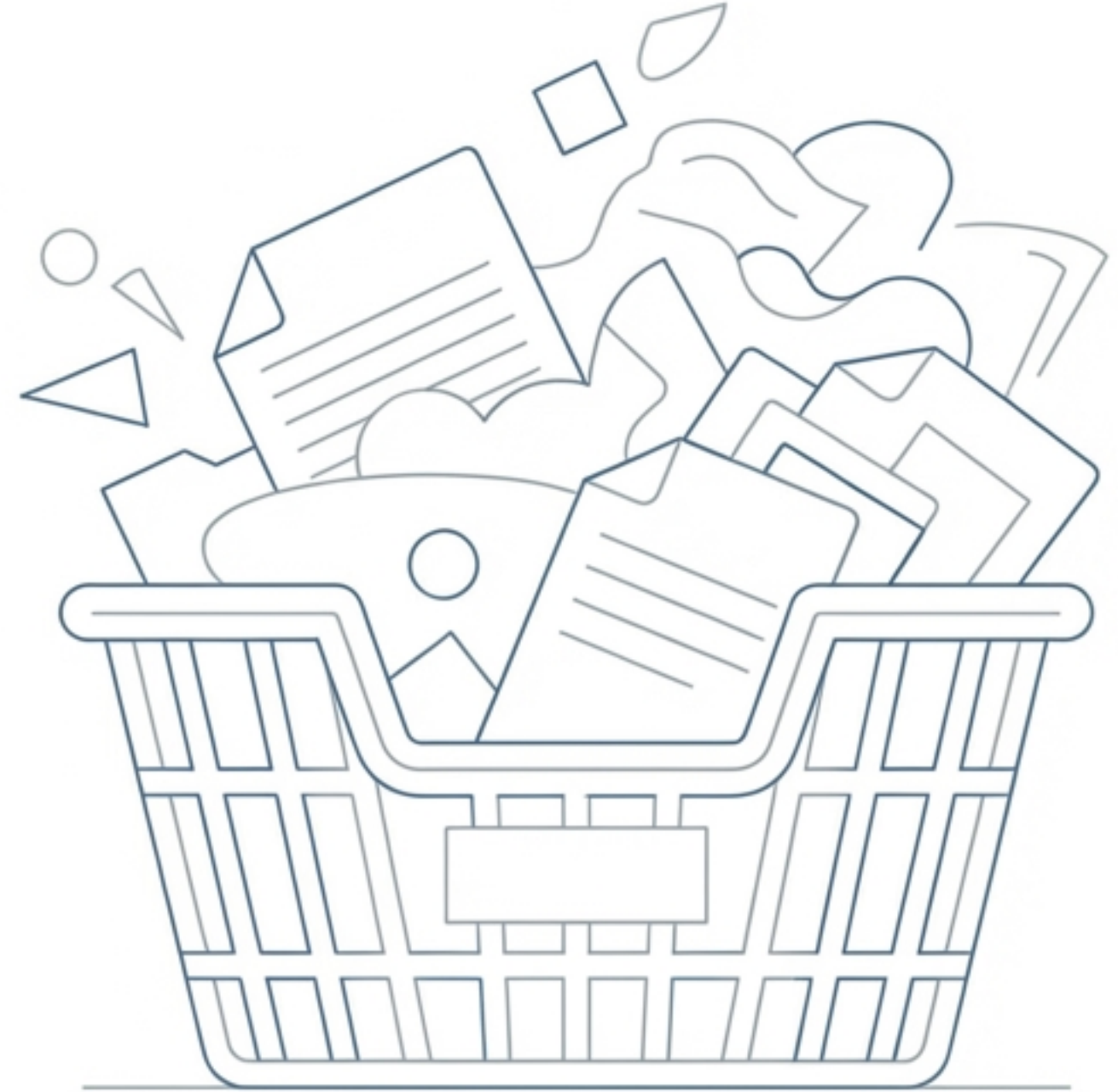
Stack buckets



Smartphone



Voice recording



Phase 2: Process

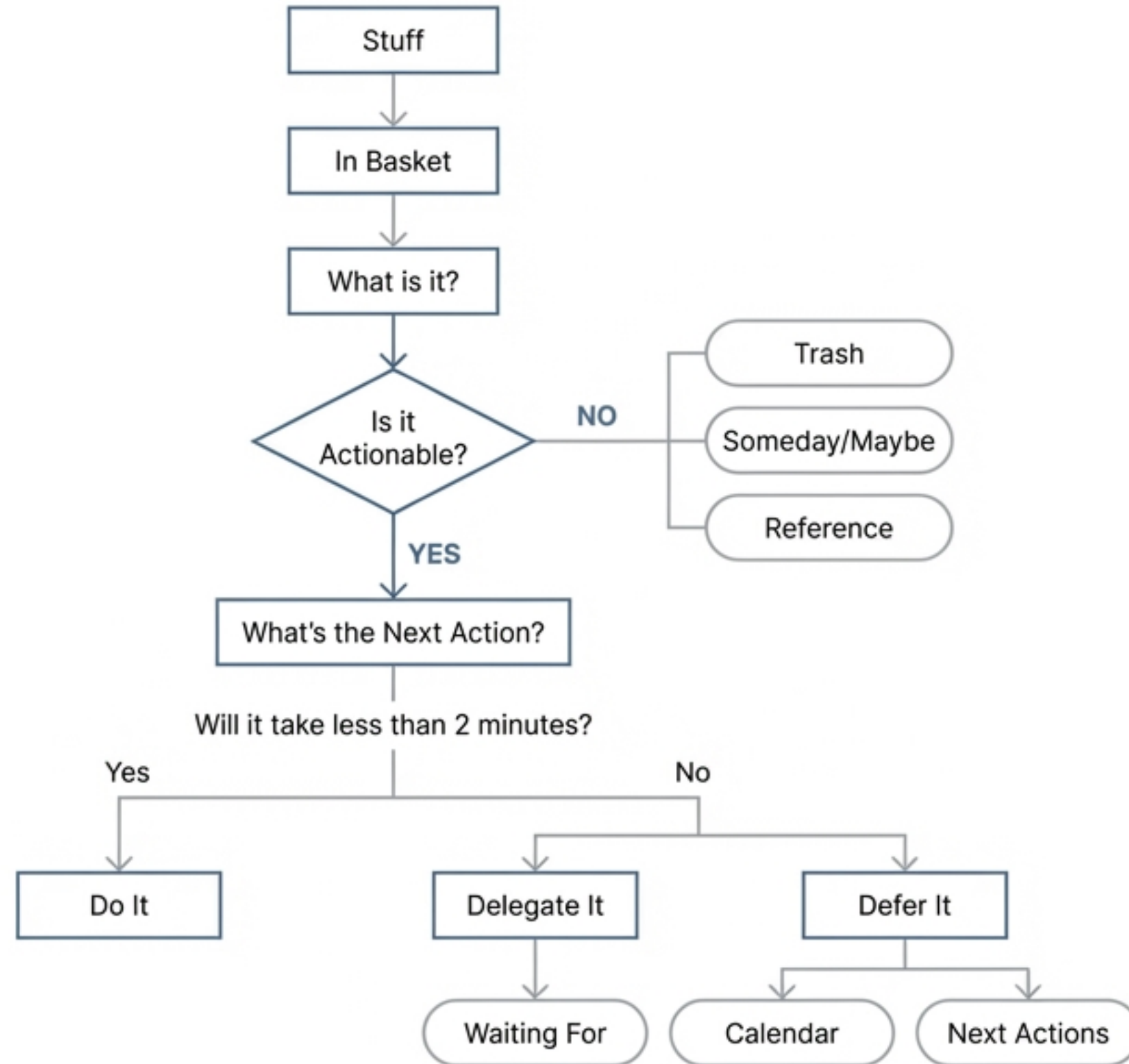
The Engine of the System

Is it Actionable?



The Golden Rule: Never put something back into 'In'. You must decide its nature immediately.

The Workflow Diagram



Managing Actionable Items

Next Action: The next physical, visible activity required to move the situation forward.
Inter Regular

Do It

The 2-Minute Rule.
If it takes < 2 mins,
do it now.



Delegate It

If > 2 mins and you
aren't the right
person. Hand it off.



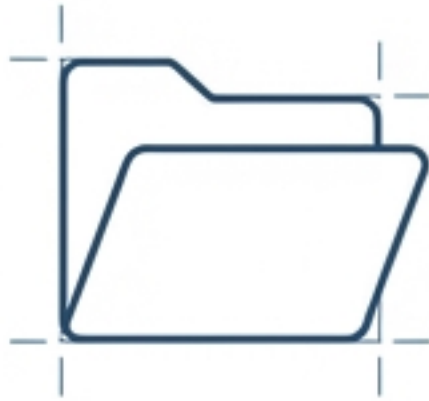
Defer It

If > 2 mins and it is
for you. Track it on a
list.



Phase 3: Organize

Projects vs. Actions



Projects List

Any desired result requiring more than one step (e.g., Hire Assistant).

This is an index of open loops. It is not a "do-list". It is a list of finish lines.



Next Actions

The specific physical steps to take.

Keep project support materials separate from action lists.

The Hard Landscape: Your Calendar

The Rule: Three things go on the calendar, and nothing else.

1. Time-specific actions (Appointments).
2. Day-specific actions (Must happen Tuesday).
3. Day-specific information.

Warning

No Daily To-Do Lists. If it's on the calendar, it must be done or rescheduled. If it's optional, it belongs on a Next Actions list.

The Next Actions Lists

Sort by Context, not Priority



Calls

When near a phone.



At Computer

When at your desk.



Errands

When you are out.



Agendas

Things to discuss with specific people.

Key Insight: When you have 15 minutes and a phone, crank through “Calls” without distraction.

Waiting For & Someday/Maybe

Waiting For

A list of external dependencies.
Review to know what you are
waiting on (e.g., Reimbursement).



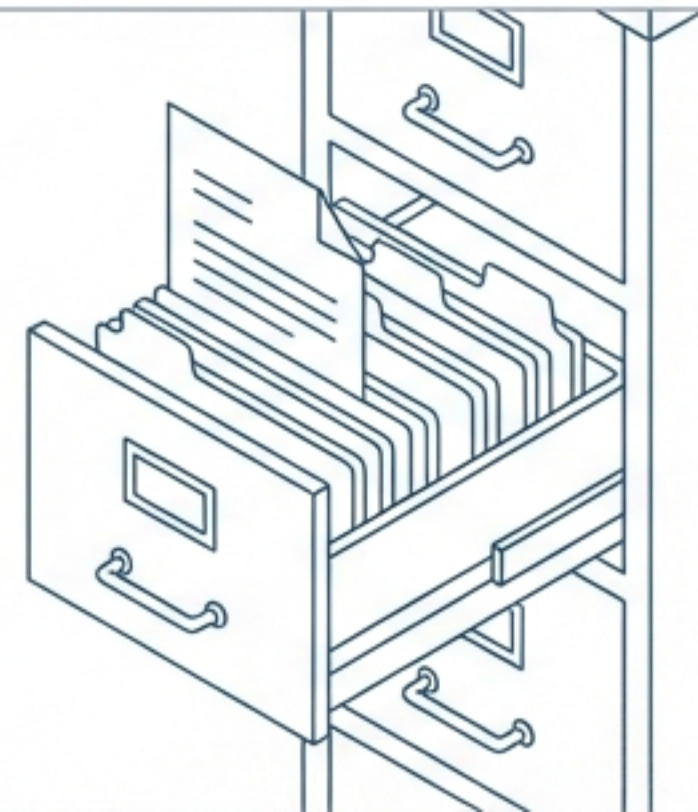
Someday/Maybe

The Parking Lot for dreams.
Projects you want to do, but not
now (e.g., Learn Spanish, Climb Everest).



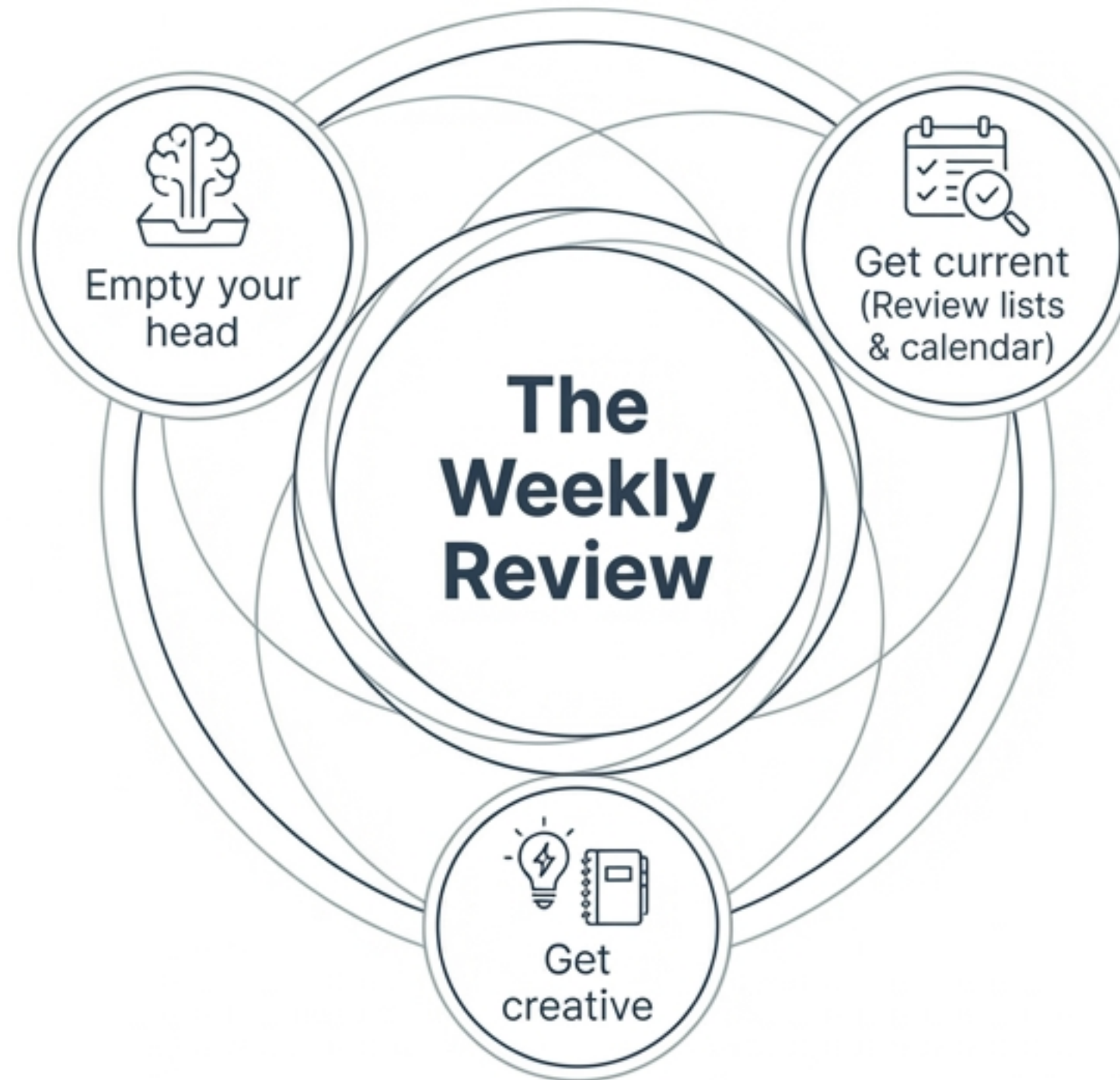
Incubation / Tickler File

Mailing information to your future self.



Phase 4: Review

The Critical Success Factor

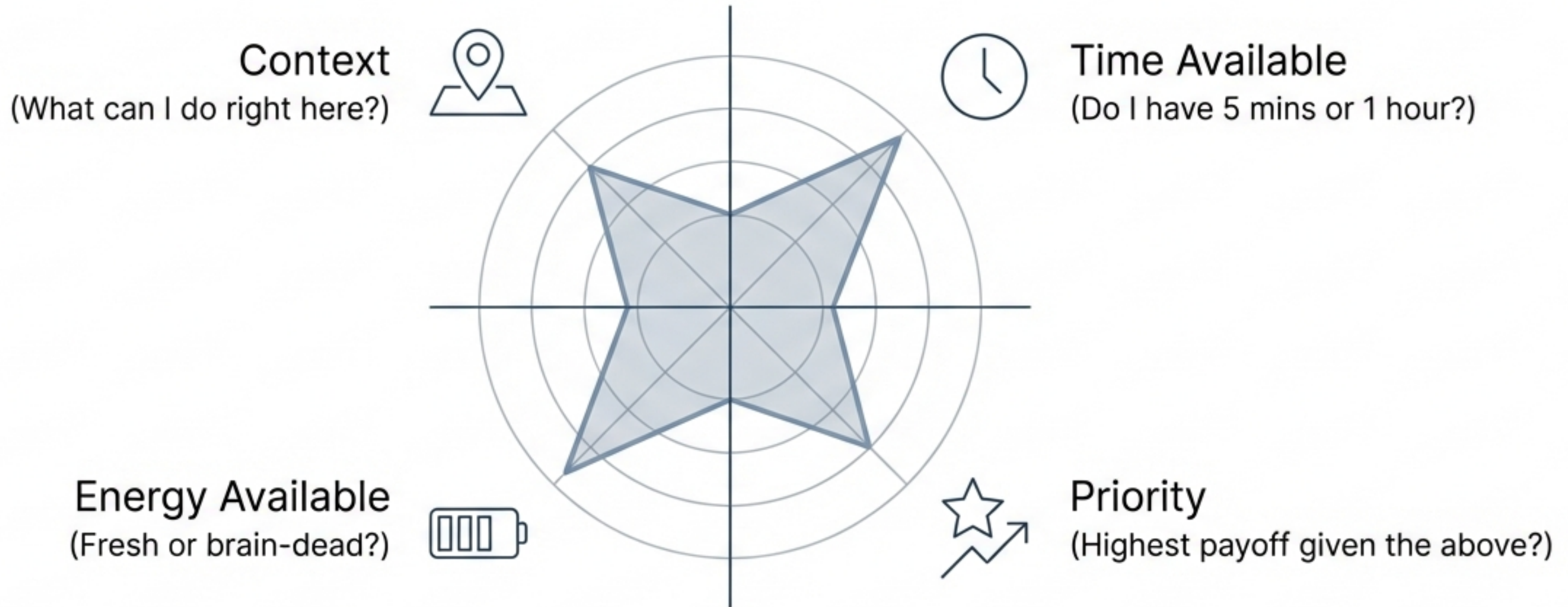


The Payoff: A 'squeaky clean' system allows you to trust your intuitive choices the rest of the week.

Phase 5: Do

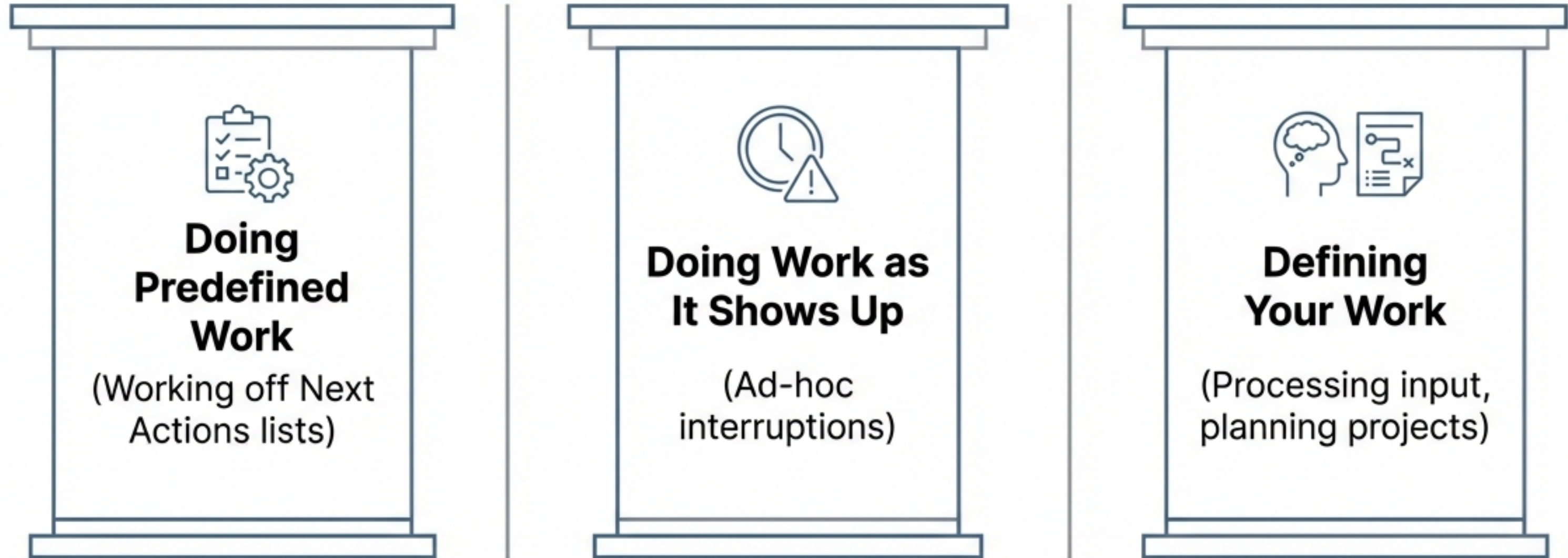
The 4-Criteria Model

How to choose what to do at 3:22 PM?



Migrate from hoping it's the right choice to trusting it's the right choice.

The Threefold Nature of Work



You must budget time for Defining Work, or you will be trapped in Work as It Shows Up. Inter Regular

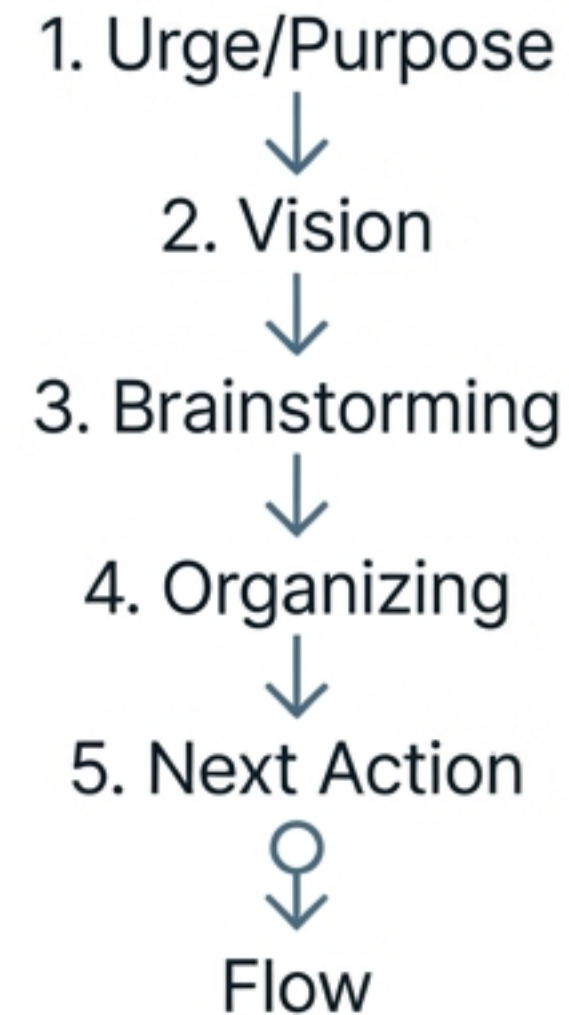


Vertical Focus: Project Planning

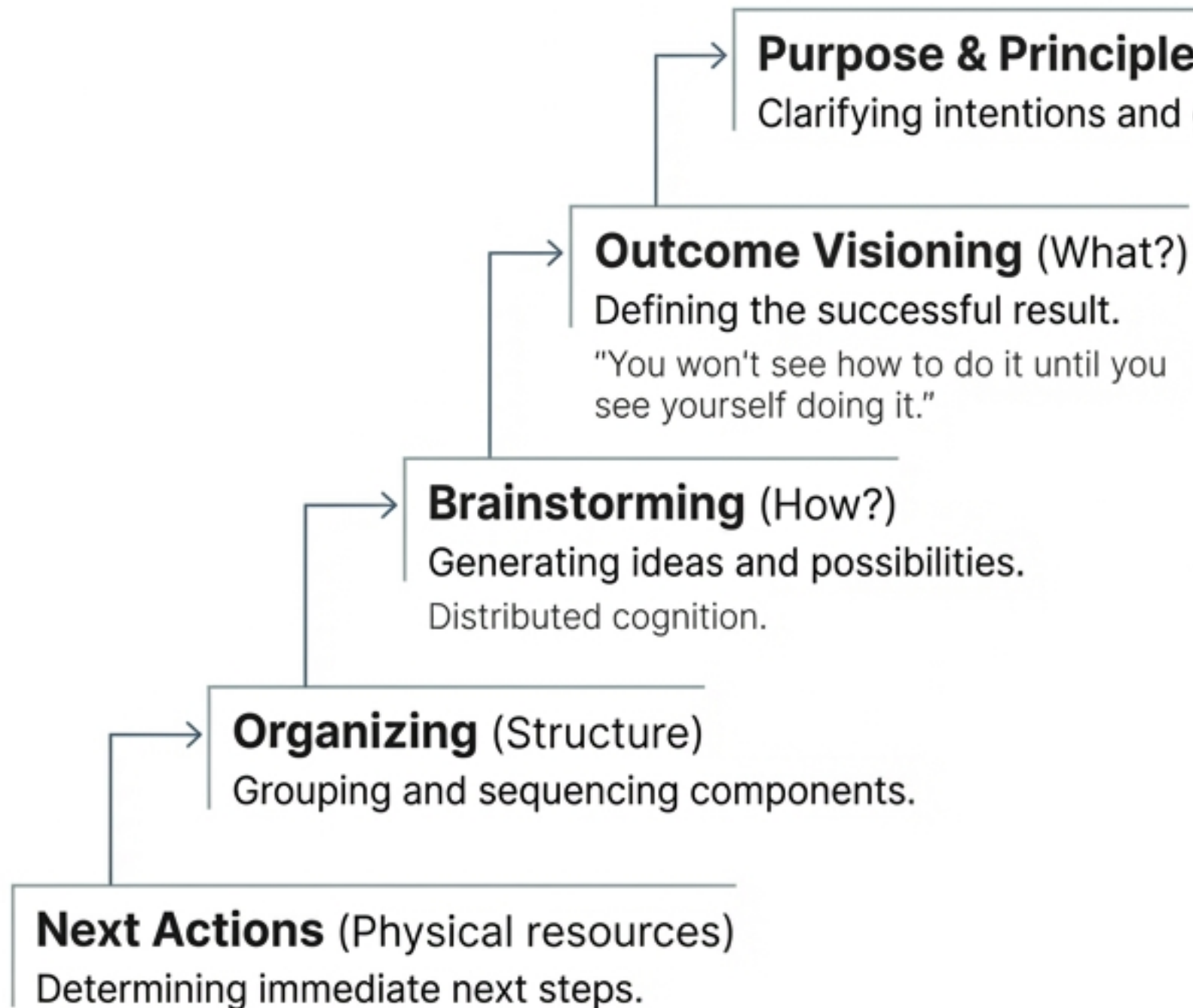
The Unnatural Model (Corporate)



The Natural Model (Brain)



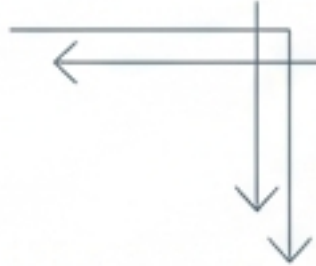
The Natural Planning Model



Getting Started

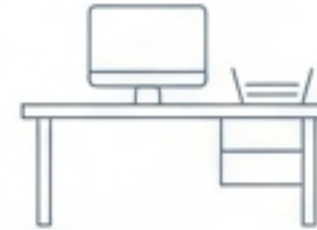
Time, Space, & Tools

Time



Set aside 2 contiguous days for initial collection.

Space



Establish a cockpit of control. Physical writing surface + In-basket.

Tools



File folders, label maker, paper, pens.

The Trick

Put it in front of the door.
Let the smart planner guide the not-so-smart doer.



The Ultimate Result



Your mind is for having ideas,
not holding them.

When you trust your system, you can devote 100% of your attention to the opportunity before you.